Eggplant & Mozzarella Celebration Cake

FROM NELL'S KITCHEN

This was one of my first creations when I started hosting at home.

Serves 8–10 · Prep 35 min · Cook 25 min

INGREDIENTS

- 3 medium eggplants, approximately 900 g, diced
- Salt, for sprinkling
- Vegetable oil, for frying
- 400 g cherry tomatoes, sliced
- A generous handful of fresh basil leaves, chopped, plus extra leaves for decorating
- 350 g mozzarella, well drained and cubed
- 3 medium ripe avocados, approximately 350–400 g flesh
- 3 tbsp olive oil, divided
- 2 tbsp balsamic vinegar
- 1 tbsp fresh lemon juice, or to taste
- Salt and freshly ground black pepper
- Balsamic glaze, for finishing

METHOD

1. Sprinkle the diced eggplants lightly with salt and leave in a colander for approximately 20 minutes. Pat thoroughly dry.
2. Heat the vegetable oil in a deep frying pan. Fry the eggplant in batches until golden and tender. Transfer to a tray lined with kitchen paper, spreading it out to drain well. Allow to cool completely.
3. Place the springform pan on a rimmed tray to catch any escaping juices.
4. Mix the sliced cherry tomatoes with the chopped basil, one tablespoon of olive oil, salt and pepper. Spoon into the pan, leaving behind any excess liquid in the bowl. Spread into an even layer and press down gently.
5. Toss the mozzarella with one tablespoon of olive oil and the balsamic vinegar. Arrange over the tomatoes, spreading it evenly to the edges.
6. Scoop the avocado flesh into a bowl. Add the lemon juice, remaining tablespoon of olive oil, salt and pepper. Mash thoroughly with a fork until it forms a smooth, thick paste. Spread carefully over the mozzarella, smoothing it into an even layer.
7. Finish with a thick, even layer of the cooled fried eggplant. This will become the base of the cake once it is turned out.
8. Using a flat plate or the flat base of a bowl that fits inside the pan, press firmly and evenly to compact the layers without forcing the avocado out at the edges. Leave a small plate on top to maintain gentle pressure, then refrigerate for at least 3 hours.
9. When ready to serve, remove the small plate. Place a serving platter over the pan and carefully invert them together.
10. Gently release and lift away the springform ring, then carefully remove the pan's base.
11. Finish with a swirl of balsamic glaze and a generous cluster of fresh basil leaves. Serve chilled, cutting carefully with a sharp knife and supporting each portion with a broad serving spatula.

Tip

Drain the eggplant thoroughly. It should be tender and golden, without carrying excess frying oil into the layers.